

"Flu cases have been rising from late last year. Hospitalisations too have increased in recent weeks, especially those with COPD, asthma or chronic bronchitis"

DR SANDEEP BUDHIRAJA, *Medical director, Max Healthcare, Delhi*

"The Influenza virus isn't becoming more aggressive. In fact, our exposure, particularly to H3N2, has been less"



DR DIPU T.S., *Associate professor, Division of Infectious Diseases, Amrita Hospital, Kochi*

Dr Aditya S. Chowti, director of internal medicine at Fortis CG Road, Bengaluru, says his city too is seeing a spike in flu cases. "We have seen a longer than usual flu season, with patients returning with the same symptoms within a week or two of recovering," he says. Dr Chowti attributes it to the unusually cold winter in the city this year and also due to daily temperature variations, with a cold morning and warm afternoons. "We have a term called Bangalore bronchitis, where people develop cold or flu like symptoms from allergens in the air. People travelling around the world are also bound to bring back viral strains," he adds.

Another reason has been the re-exposure to the flu post the Covid-19 pandemic. "During Covid, everyone was masked or in isolation," says Dr Budhiraja. "This prevented us from getting the flu. The flu virus transmission was low and the body's resistance and immunity against it also went down. So, for those three years, the immunity status globally against the flu virus might have reduced."

Though two strains of the Type A virus and one of Type B are fueling the infections this time, it was H3N2 that was the predominant subtype for the first three months of 2023, causing more cases than both H1N1 and Covid. So, for the first nine weeks (January 2-March 5) of 2023, the Indian Council of Medical Research (ICMR) surveillance network recorded 451 cases of H3N2 (against 41 cases of H1N1), including seven deaths.

The illness is longer with H3N2, with patients complaining of a dry, hacking persistent cough. But most people recover from this highly contagious strain within a week. At-risk patients, however, have the danger of developing complications such as pneumonia, bronchitis, and even death. According to ICMR, in the 2023 outbreak of H3N2, about 10 per cent of patients suffered from Severe Acute Respiratory Infection (SARI), requiring oxygen support, while seven per cent required ICU care. ICMR data also showed that out of all the patient admissions in hospitals with SARI in 2023, 50 per cent were detected with H3N2.

How to stay safe

Seasonal influenza viruses spread through coughing and sneezing, but also through hands contaminated with the flu virus. To prevent transmission, people need to revert to pandemic protocol—cover their mouth and nose with a tissue when coughing/ sneezing and wash their hands regularly. They should also avoid crowded places and, if necessary, wear a mask. To prevent the infection from getting severe, it is necessary to consult a doctor within the first 48 hours of the onset of symptoms. "For high-risk patients, these guidelines are important," says Dr Budhiraja. "The flu, if it turns severe, can be life-threatening as well."

Dr Tayal also advises against attempts to self-medicate. "You should not use paracetamol and steam inhalation without consulting a doctor." You should also not take antibiotics or steroids without a prescription. In fact, as Dr Tayal puts it, "You do not need to take any medication at first. Most flu illnesses subside with a combination of rest, nutritious food and fluids."

Another way to prevent a flu infection is to take a vaccine. The new influenza vaccines protect against four strains—both strains of influenza A and two strains of influenza B. "A new vaccine comes up every year, with perhaps a slightly different composition depending upon the dominant strain of virus in that geography," says Dr Budhiraja. "This new vaccine is usually released around September for north India. This is the best time to take it." There is a strong chance the vaccine will give you cross-protection against other flu strains as well, but its effects last only for about a year. No vaccine is 100 per cent protective either. "It will, however, greatly reduce chances of severe symptoms and mortality," adds Dr Budhiraja.

Unfortunately, despite the availability of the flu shot, doctors say demand has been fairly low. "Most people think that child vaccines are mandatory, but adult ones don't matter. That is not true at all. One needs protection at various stages of life," says Dr Chowti. Advice one would do well to heed. ■